

the isles of the sea began to give submission to the power that had in a night strode out of the unknown wilds of Asia and broken rudely upon the dreams of the Greeks, not only in the islands, but even in the peninsula itself.

Cyrus had now prepared the way for the absorption of Babylonia, with its valuable possessions in Syro-Phoenicia along the Mediterranean coast. While these far-reaching conquests were awaking alarm, even in distant Greece, Nabonidus was paying no heed, busily absorbed as ever in the building and restoring and exploring for ancient foundation stones. The record of his fatuous course is written in the sententious phrases of the Babylonian Chronicle, which record his residence in Tema. In 549, when the Lydian king was full of preparations for the struggle which he knew to be inevitable, Nabonidus was in Tema. In 547 he was still in Tema, and did not even enter Babylon to pay reverence at the great shrine of the gods, or to direct the urgent affairs of state. On the fifth day of the month of Nisan the king's mother died at Dur-Karasu, on the Euphrates above Sippar, and for her a great mourning was made. But on that same day Cyrus crossed the Tigris below Arbela and entered Assyria. Belshazzar was in northern Accad with an army, and on him were such hopes of defense as the country may have felt.

The Chronicle is now badly broken, as an examination of the copy¹ will show, and we are not able to follow the events from year to year. When next the narrative is resumed the year 539 has been reached and Nabonidus is busy removing gods from their shrines to Babylon. In that same year Cyrus met Belshazzar at

¹ See Schrader, *Keilinschriftliche Bibliothek*, iii, 2, p. 128f.